

Class 8 History Chapter 1: How, When and Where

1. How Important Are Dates?

- History is closely associated with dates because dates help us track specific events, battles, and changes over time (e.g., the exact date of a historical figure's death or a major war).
- However, not all historical changes have a specific date. Some things happen over a long period. For example, people in India didn't start drinking tea on one specific day; it became a habit over a span of time. For such processes, we use a period or timeline rather than a precise date.

2. Which Dates are Important?

- Dates are not important on their own. They become important based on the events we choose to focus on.
- For example, in histories written by British historians in India, the focus was always on the rule of British Governors-General. Therefore, all the important dates were linked to their lives and policies. If the focus of the study changes to the lives of ordinary Indians, a completely new set of dates will become important.

3. How Do We Periodize? (James Mill's Division)

- In 1817, **James Mill**, a Scottish economist and political philosopher, published a massive three-volume book called *A History of British India*.
- He divided Indian history into three periods based on the religion of the rulers: **Hindu**, **Muslim**, and **British**.
- **The Problem:** This division was heavily flawed. It is wrong to label an entire historical period just by the religion of the kings, because people of many different faiths always lived together. For example, during the Mughal era, it wasn't just Muslims who existed; Hindus and others were there too.
- Mill also believed that Indians lacked "civic sense" and that the British needed to conquer and control all of India to "civilize" its people.

4. What is Colonization?

- When one country conquers another and controls its political, economic, social, and cultural systems, the subjugated country becomes a "colony."
- The actual process of one country taking control of another in this way is known as **Colonization**. India was colonized by the British.

5. How Do We Know? (Sources of History) To write about the modern history of India, historians look at several sources:

- **Official Records:** The British believed in the act of writing. Every instruction, plan, policy, and investigation had to be clearly written up. They set up **Record Rooms** in all administrative offices (like the Tahsildar's office and the Collectorate) to preserve these documents. Expert writers called *calligraphists* beautifully copied these records. Today, many of these are preserved in the National Archives and Museums.
- **Surveys:** The British believed that a country had to be properly known before it could be ruled. They conducted various surveys to map the land, check the soil quality for growing crops, and understand the local flora and fauna (Botanical, Zoological, and Forest surveys). By the end of the 19th century, **Census** operations were conducted every 10 years to record the population, castes, and religions.
- **What Official Records Do Not Tell (Unofficial Records):** Official records only show what the British government thought and did. They hid the harsh realities like poverty or starvation. To understand what ordinary people (peasants, tribals, and workers) felt, historians rely on **unofficial records**. These include personal diaries, letters written by leaders (like Bhagat Singh or Mahatma Gandhi), autobiographies, and accounts of pilgrims and travelers.